Qualitative Research Case: Digital Nomads in China

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Overview

Working on the Move: Understanding the Needs of Chinese Digital Nomads and Comparing Domestic and Overseas Communities

An independently designed and delivered qualitative field study of a small, scattered and highly mobile population. It combined in-depth interviews, online ethnography and key informant interviews to examine why people adopt a nomadic work-life model, what their communities provide, and how those communities relate to their host neighborhoods.

Researcher	Institution	Project type	Period
Ruisi Ma	School of Social Research, Renmin University of China (B.A. Sociology)	Undergraduate thesis, designed and completed independently	Jan 2024 – Apr 2024

Interviews	Communities studied	Online groups observed	Key informants
14 semi-structured in-depth interviews, 60–90 min each (about 14–21 hours of interview data)	**10** communities: **8** in China and **2** overseas (Chiang Mai, Bali)	**4** online groups, via participant observation, plus content from **4** social media platforms	**9** interviewees with community living experience, including **3** founders of popular communities

Recognition

Award / result	Awarded by	Year	Note
Beijing Outstanding Undergraduate Thesis Award	Beijing Municipal Education Commission	2024	Top 0.9% of undergraduate theses
First Prize, Outstanding Undergraduate Graduation Thesis	Renmin University of China	2024	University-level award

Award / result	Awarded by	Year	Note
Thesis defense score	Renmin University of China	2024	95 / 100

01 Research Background & Questions

As remote work spread after 2020, "digital nomads" quickly gained traction in China, and co-living communities sprang up in Dali, Anji, Xiamen, Quanzhou and elsewhere. The group is small, scattered and highly mobile, and existing research relies mostly on Western samples, which explain Chinese users poorly. The project addressed three questions:

- Why do people leave office jobs in tier-1 cities for a lifestyle of "remote work + living across multiple places"? What are the push and pull factors?
- Which needs do digital nomad communities meet? How do domestic and overseas communities differ, and why?
- How do these communities interact with local residents, and what effects do they have on their host neighborhoods?

02 Research Design & Execution

I ran the full research cycle alone, from problem definition to final report.

1. **Scoping:** Reviewed existing literature and media coverage to define the research questions and identify gaps in Western-based studies.
2. **Instrument design:** Built a semi-structured interview guide with five modules: work and life before the transition, key decision points, current work and lifestyle, community living experience, and future plans.
3. **Sampling and recruitment:** Designed a maximum-variation sample and recruited participants with no existing sampling frame.
4. **Fieldwork:** Conducted interviews, online observation and key informant interviews in parallel.
5. **Data processing:** Transcribed all interviews verbatim and coded them line by line.
6. **Synthesis:** Cross-checked sources, built a needs framework, segmented users and compared communities.
7. **Reporting:** Wrote up findings, practical implications and limitations in the final thesis.

Method	What was done	Role in the study
In-depth interviews	14 semi-structured interviews, 60–90 minutes each, following the five-module guide above, with follow-up probes on concrete decisions and experiences	Understand individual motivations and decision-making
Online ethnography	Systematic keyword collection of posts and videos on Xiaohongshu, Weibo, WeChat Official Accounts and Zhihu; joined 4 online digital nomad groups and took part in activities and discussions	Observe group operations, event organization and member interaction; check interview accounts against observed behavior
Key informant interviews	9 interviewees had lived in communities, including 3 founders of popular communities	First-hand view of community operations, rules and relations with locals

Execution highlights

- **Sampling:** Followed a maximum-variation principle covering four employment statuses (salaried remote employees, freelancers, entrepreneurs and community founders, and career explorers in transition). The sample also varied by gender, marital status, age (24–33), time spent traveling and whether participants had a fixed base, so that no single user type dominated the findings.
- **Recruitment of a hard-to-reach group:** The population has no membership list or registry. I identified candidates through their public posts, invited them by direct message on Xiaohongshu, then expanded through snowball referrals. All recruitment was done independently.
- **Community sample:** 8 communities in China (5 co-living communities, 1 shared coworking group and 2 online groups) and 2 overseas communities in Chiang Mai and Bali, providing a basis for domestic–overseas comparison.
- **Triangulation:** Compared what interviewees said with what was observed in online groups and what founders reported about operations, to separate individual impressions from patterns shared across sources.
- **Analysis:** Coded transcripts line by line and grouped codes into themes drawn from interviewees' own words. Themes were organized into a push–pull needs framework across three dimensions (work content, time arrangement and living space). Users

were then segmented by their motivation for the transition, and communities were compared on a common set of dimensions.

03 Key Insights

Insight 1: User motivations cluster around four needs

Autonomy over what work to take on, flexibility in scheduling, a livable environment close to nature, and genuine, close relationships. The regional arbitrage of "tier-1 income + low cost of living" provides essential practical support. Emphasis differs by user type: freelancers care more about deciding which projects to take, while salaried workers care more about skipping the commute and truly owning their time after work.

Insight 2: User segments and divergent attitudes

By motivation for the transition, users fall into three types: those resetting their pace after work-life imbalance, those treating nomadic life as a "gap year" phase before returning to the workplace, and those choosing a slow-paced lifestyle for the long term. Attitudes toward "drifting" also split: some feel anxious about choosing a base, while others need no fixed base at all and enjoy mobility itself.

Insight 3: Communities serve two core functions

Social connection and emotional support, which ease the loneliness of constant movement; and **career mutual aid**, through personal sharing sessions, peer exchanges, job and resource matching, and co-learning activities. Some online groups evolved from simple Q&A into job-matching channels as member needs grew.

Insight 4: Domestic and overseas communities differ markedly

Dimension	Domestic (Dali, Anji, etc.)	Overseas (Chiang Mai, Bali)
Member profile	Highly mixed, with a large share of career explorers and curious short-term visitors	Mostly experienced digital nomads, highly international
Operating model	Strongly self-organized: members initiate events through WeChat group sign-ups, and founders deliberately downplay their own role	Highly commercialized: tiered membership pricing, with operators planning weekly events

Dimension	Domestic (Dali, Anji, etc.)	Overseas (Chiang Mai, Bali)
Activities	Rich in career mutual aid (industry sharing, roundtables, co-learning)	Centered on cultural experiences and leisure (surfing, diving, yoga, etc.)
Closeness of ties	Small communities are tight-knit; interviewees likened them to "a college dorm"	Activities are often organized across communities via local online groups; ties within any one community are looser

> **Why they differ:** Domestic communities have more career explorers, which creates stronger demand for career support and drives the growth of mutual-aid functions. Members of international communities come from different countries and job markets, so professional exchange faces natural barriers, and cultural differences raise the bar for deeper relationships.

Insight 5: Relations with host communities depend on each community's positioning

Communities vary widely in how open they are to local residents. Some are open only to residents; others open their kitchens and events fully to neighbors, and even co-host ethnic festival celebrations with local people. A community's positioning and operating philosophy directly shape its relationship with the people around it. The study also examined the communities' possible gentrification effects on their host neighborhoods, an issue directly relevant to how incoming groups and projects affect local residents.

04 Reflections & Limitations

- Communities vary widely from place to place; more robust conclusions would require long-term on-site observation.
- The sample concentrates on people aged 24–33 who travel mainly within China; cross-border nomads and older groups warrant separate study.
- Interviewees held fairly similar values, which may introduce sample bias; the study states the scope of its conclusions explicitly.

05 Relevance to the Social Consulting Associate Role (ERM)

Role requirement	Evidence from this project
Socio-economic surveys and social screening	Designed a structured interview guide and collected first-hand data on employment, income–cost trade-offs, housing and mobility from a scattered, hard-to-reach population
Social impact and community-level analysis	Examined how communities relate to local residents and assessed possible gentrification effects on host neighborhoods
Stakeholder identification and engagement	Mapped and engaged distinct groups (four user types, community founders and operators) and built enough trust with cold-contacted strangers to hold 60–90 minute interviews
Qualitative field methods	Combined in-depth interviews, online ethnography and key informant interviews, and triangulated findings across sources
Social data management and analysis	Transcribed and coded all interviews systematically, turning raw data into a needs framework, user segments and a comparison matrix; complemented by quantitative training (R, Stata, Python) from an M.S. in Survey and Data Science
Independent project delivery	Handled scoping, research design, recruitment, fieldwork, analysis and report writing alone within four months
Cross-cultural comparison	Compared communities in China, Thailand and Indonesia and explained differences through member composition, market context and operating model
Report writing	Produced a full research report that received a 95/100 defense score and a Beijing-level award; this case summary is written in English